

engine to the backbeat of ZZ Top's *La Grange* or your own custom soundtrack—ripped to the Xbox's hard disk. The game is a stickler for detail for those who demand it, while being accessible for those just looking to burn rubber—a well-balanced addition to an Xbox owner's library.

Fable

Fable used to be an Xbox exclusive, but is now also available on the PC as *Fable: Lost Chapters*, with extra content thrown in. Being a Lionhead creation, the game is obsessed with virtue and good, and the shadows an ego can cast, which passes for evil. The game marches to this good/evil beat, tracking every deed you do, no matter how small or seemingly insignificant, and logging it within its memory banks like some digital god. (It even tracks how far you can kick chickens. Yes, you can kick chickens in *Fable*.)

Unlike real life, *Fable* reflects your characters deeds visually—a bad avatar will grow horns, a good one will be beatific to behold. It's an interesting reflection on how our culture associates appearance with morality. The game is also laced with typical British humour; interacting with the world's inhabitants is also a joy. Women will fall in love with you, you will age and scar as time passes, you can tattoo your body and face, change your hairstyle, wear ridiculous or cool armour, walk around in your undies, go Conan with muscles if you use swords much, or bald if you cast too many spells... our most memorable experience was when one evening, our avatar got stinking drunk in the local tavern and then proceeded to get others just as drunk—while watching women throw up all over the place was nice, better was when the kids mimicked your drunken swagger and formed giggly beelines behind you. Oh yeah, the game also has a good story, a great combat and spell system, interesting quests and a unique style of presentation. Another must-have!



ALSO ON The Xbox

- 1 Halo: Combat Evolved
- 1 Halo 2
- 1 Full Spectrum Warrior
- 1 Brothers in Arms: Earned in Blood
- 1 Burnout Revenge
- 1 World Soccer Winning Eleven 9
- 1 Def Jam: Fight for NY
- 1 Need for Speed Most Wanted
- 1 Unreal Championship 2: The Liandri Conflict

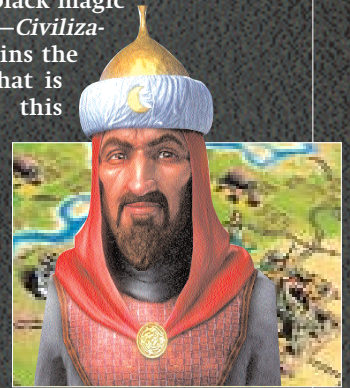
THE PC

Consoles have certainly carved off a healthy chunk from our PC habit. With the release of the Xbox, every game went multiplatform overnight, sometimes to the detriment of our beloved computer. While console gaming has

its uses, some genres are still best experienced on the Pee Cee:

Civilization IV

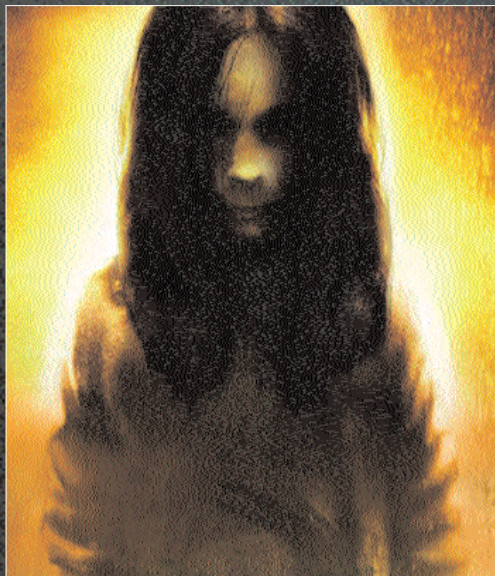
One more turn. Just one more turn. One more. Just another. Right through the night and on to dawn. It's the evil black magic of a Sid Meier game—*Civilization IV* (Civ IV) retains the addictive quality that is the hallmark of this series. If you on unfamiliar territory here, Civ IV is a turn-based strategy title that puts you in charge of the major civilizations of the world, with a view to dominate and emerge victorious.



Victory is possible through a range of tactics—from war, to cultural hegemony, to scientific domination; even religion is factored into this particular outing. Role-play a variety of leaders, from Gandhiji to Genghis Khan, alone or with friends—over the Internet, or on a LAN, or even via e-mail. The game can be a bit overwhelming at its onset but once you get familiar with its key concepts, prepare to feed yourself intravenously as you stay glued to your monitor for hours at end. As a bonus incentive to buy this insta-classic—it's voiced by Leonard Nimoy of Mr. Spock fame. Civ long and prosperous!

F.E.A.R.

A game from Monolith is seldom wrong and *F.E.A.R.* just reaffirms the development studio's knack for creating games of the highest caliber. It is just as rare for a first-person shooter to



communicate the visceral horror that must ebb through a gun fight. This game talks the talk. You can feel the weight of each bullet as it leaves the muzzle of your gun, you can taste the fear as wood and brick inches away, turn up clouds of dust and dirt to enemy fire; bodies slump and tear, glass shards the air, one moment there is the rat-tat-tat and the thoom-thoom of guns blazing and the next instant it's all over. Silence, bodies, dust,

you live. The name of the game also points to a supernatural plot that adds a psychological weight to the *F.E.A.R.* motif. Let's just say bullets and bombs won't be the only thing you would be afraid of while playing this game.